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EAST ASIA TO KOLKATA

Yokocho offers charcoal-fired flavours with local produce, and cocktails laced with khejur gur **P4**

metroPLUS THE HINDU



Shape of summer

With rising temperatures and harsher summers, SS/26 collections turn to mulmul, kala cotton and Chanderi, pairing them with silhouettes built for airflow, comfort and wearability

life through kalamkari. Tuscan poppies, coastal bougainvillea and Provençal wildflowers come to life through the kalamkari pen on handwoven silks and intricate embroidery.

“Handwoven lightweight silks are the main focus of our collection because it provides a natural fluidity and breathability. The emphasis is on silhouettes such as flowing kurta sets, capes, layered separates, and relaxed ensembles. The cuts are made to be comfortable while maintaining a sense of quiet luxury,” says Archana.

Anavila Misra, with her SS’26 collection Oh, Bonita! (costing upwards of ₹13,500) takes that argument even further, almost to the point of stating the obvious. “Summer fabrics have always been about performance, we’re only starting to call it that now,” she says. It is a line that cuts through a lot of the current language around climate-conscious dressing. Fabrics like mulmul, Kota, Mangalgiri, and linen were never designed to be nostalgic. “They naturally breathe, absorb sweat, and keep the body cool,” she explains, adding that while poly blends might be easier to maintain, they tend to trap heat and feel harsher on the skin over time.

Her approach does not try to fix what is not broken. “These textiles were always climate smart to begin with,” she says, pointing to linen and fine-count

khadi cotton as fabrics that already do what they need to. The changes, where they happen, are more visual than functional. Weaves are adjusted to bring in a more contemporary feel, but without interfering with how the fabric behaves. The real work, she suggests, lies in how the garment is cut and worn, in “silhouettes and drapes that allow ease, movement, and airflow,” letting the fabric fall the way it is meant to rather than forcing it into structure.

The Bonita pink dress, made from cotton silk, works particularly well for summer with its pintuck texture, especially on a lightweight base. It helps keep the fabric from sitting flat against the skin, allowing for a bit more airflow, while the easy, fluid silhouette creates space for movement through the day.

Form and structure
At Delhi-based Bodice, founder and creative director Ruchika Sachdeva speaks about balance. “Our SS’26 collection is built on our affinity for balance while keeping the season’s elements intact.” The silhouettes hold their shape, but the fabrics soften that structure. “They move, drape, and breathe,” she says. The result is pieces (costing upwards of ₹12,500) that are not overly relaxed nor rigid, but attentive to both.

Delhi-based label Lovebirds takes that idea a step further. Their Resort 26/27 collection, shown at Lunuganga in Sri Lanka, draws from the work of architect Geoffrey Bawa, whose approach to Tropical Modernism was rooted in working with the climate rather than against it. The clothes follow a similar logic. Structured, almost architectural in parts, but made in fabrics that allow for movement and airflow.

The palette stays restrained, largely black and ecru, with batik running through the collection as material language. The batik technique, centuries old, involves applying wax by hand to fabric to resist dye, with patterns revealed only once the wax is removed, making it as much about foresight as skill.

Additionally, batik is traditionally worked on lightweight, breathable fabrics like cotton and silk, which handle heat and humidity well. The process does not alter the fabric’s structure in a lasting way, so once the wax is removed, the material retains its ability to breathe and absorb moisture. In coastal areas, where the air is heavy and damp, it makes a noticeable difference.

There is also a practical side to the prints. Batik patterns tend to be layered and irregular, which can help mask sweat and everyday wear, making them more forgiving than solid, lighter colours.

For a long time, summer dressing has been about how clothes look in the heat. Now, there is a growing awareness of how they actually behave in it.



(Clockwise from left) Looks from collections by Lovebirds; Anavila; Archana Jaju; Jodi; Bodice; Payal Singhal; and Saaksha & Kinni. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

especially in the context of overproduction.

A new vernacular
At Jodi, the starting point feels less mediated. “There is a particular kind of time that only exists by the sea. This collection emerged from that,” says co-founder Karuna Laungani of the Pune-based brand’s SS/26 collection, Only Fools and Fish (costing upwards of ₹9,000). “We began, as we always do, with the fabric,” she says, referring to kala cotton, mul, and Chanderi, which have been used for the collection.

Kala cotton, grown in Kutch, holds up well in dry conditions and does not demand much water. Mul lets air move through it easily. Chanderi, when it is kept light, layers without becoming oppressive. “They breathe with you rather than against you,” says Karuna, which is a simple way of putting it, but also the most accurate.

There is no attempt here to engineer the experience. “There are no synthetics or polyester, and no shortcuts,” she adds. The clothes (all hand-dyed and block-printed in Jaipur) from the collection carry the mark of how they are made, with prints that do not align perfectly, embroidery that feels considered, and colour that settles unevenly.

Between these two positions sits a more pragmatic approach. “I think nostalgia is just one layer of the story,” says Saaksha Bhat of Saaksha & Kinni, speaking about the label’s SS/26 collection, Estampa (costing upwards of ₹11,000). “For us, these fabrics have always been about performance first.”

Mulmul, she points out, was never meant to be romantic.



“They (fabrics) breathe, they absorb, and most importantly, they allow the body to regulate temperature naturally.” What has changed is the awareness. “We’re thinking about how a garment will feel at 35 degrees with humidity, not just how it will look in a photograph,” says Saaksha.

Estampa leans into print rather than away from it, bringing together *kalamkari*, block printing, bandhini and kantha in a way that feels visually dense but materially light. These are techniques traditionally worked on cotton and other breathable bases, which means the clothes hold up in heat even when they do not look ‘minimal’. In fact, the prints do some of the work that summer whites often

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Summer dressing in India still follows a predictable shorthand: Linen, whites, or something ‘breezy’.

It sounds right, until you step outside and realise that the heat is getting harder to contend with every year, as summers get warmer. With temperatures routinely hovering around the 43–45°C mark across central and eastern regions, it is time to rethink our traditional summer wardrobes.

For a long time, we wore fabric that could handle the weather. Mulmul that let air pass through without much resistance. Cotton that absorbed sweat and did not sit too heavily on the body. Even linen, which is not historically rooted in India in the same way, slipped easily into the wardrobe because it behaved well in dry heat.

What is changing now is not the fabric so much as the way it is being framed. There is still a version of summer that fashion prefers to sell, one that feels edited, and far removed from the conditions it claims to respond to. This is changing.

Payal Singhal described her SS/26 collection Shahnameh, as “a foundation of lightness both in fabric and philosophy,” with “airy silks, organzas, and fluid blends... chosen for their breathability and ease”.

The clothes move easily, look effortless, and the thinking extends into how it is made, with nearly 90% of the collection produced on a made-to-order basis – a considered approach,

pick of the week



Say cheese!

If your idea of comfort food begins with cheese, head to Focaccia at Hyatt Regency Chennai tonight for a seven-course dinner with cheese-forward dishes.

Served from 7pm, the menu includes tuna and mango samosa with Tomme, octo-cheese paniyaram with Comté, lasagne with Canestrato, and sous vide chicken with Raclette. Penfolds wines accompany the meal.

Prices start at ₹4,500.



Timing the force

Ahead of the release of *Star Wars: The Mandalorian and Grogu*, Fossil has launched two limited-edition watches in India. The 42mm Everett Mandalorian model

references Din Djarin's beskar armour with a gunmetal steel bracelet and Clan Mudhorn detailing, while the 38mm Neutra Grogu edition features pram-inspired accents. Both watches come in sound-enabled collector boxes.

Prices start at ₹24,495 on fossil.com.



Backing act

The Chennai Scene, a platform supporting the city's independent artists, is co-hosting a five-day fundraiser concert Turn Up For Devoid at Aura Studios for the treatment of Devanand

aka Devoid, a rapper who was injured in a car accident last month. Running through May 10, from 5.30pm, the line-up includes Gonzy, Sokku, Tupakeys and Voltage B. Entry via a minimum donation of ₹1,000.

Register on forms.gle/uN82cwy99WR4j9RB7



Sole choice

The Spring/Summer capsule of Anaar, a luxury footwear brand, champions maximalist design aesthetics. The collection's hand-embroidered slip-on

mules, wedge sandals, white sneakers, and ballerinas feature craft techniques like beadwork, gemstones, zardozi and 3D florals on textiles like denim, jute and raffia.

The collection is priced upwards of ₹3,990 on shopanaar.com.

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Twenty years after their first partnership with designer Stella McCartney, fashion retailer H&M launched their second collaboration with the luxury label from the UK on May 7. It blends current signature styles such as oversized shirts, sweeping trenches and sharp tailoring with "playful, iconic hits from McCartney's early archive", including bejewelled prints and slogan tops.

Ann-Sofie Johansson, head of Design, Womenswear and creative advisor, H&M, calls McCartney a "rule breaker".

"She was H&M's second-ever designer collaboration, after Karl Lagerfeld. Stella is not afraid to challenge the conventions of the industry and to present an inspiring and hopeful vision of how to do things differently. That is what attracted us to her 20 years ago: we felt she had vigour and energy and ideas for how to disrupt the industry, especially when it came to material. And recently, we decided that we wanted to champion that again, and keep those discussions going, hence this collection," says Ann-Sofie, who has collaborated closely with renowned brands such as Balmain, Rabanne, Moschino, and Mugler.

Highlights from the drop include rib knitted dresses and tops with McCartney's signature Falabella chain at the neck; a long white gown with a cape-like sleeve that loops into the hem; alongside partywear, separates, denims, mesh dresses, and tops. On the accessories front, there will be bags in six styles including shoulder bags and totes, and a selection of necklaces, earrings crafted from recycled metal. "There are some throwbacks that people will love, like the 'Rock Royalty' white mini tee, which is a homage to a style worn by Stella herself, and Liv Tyler, at the 1999 Met Gala. There are innovative fabrications within the collection like the usage of feedstock for coated materials, such as industrial corn and



A stellar collab

From Falabella chain knits to recycled-material accessories, the new H&M and Stella McCartney collaboration blends past icons with future-focussed design



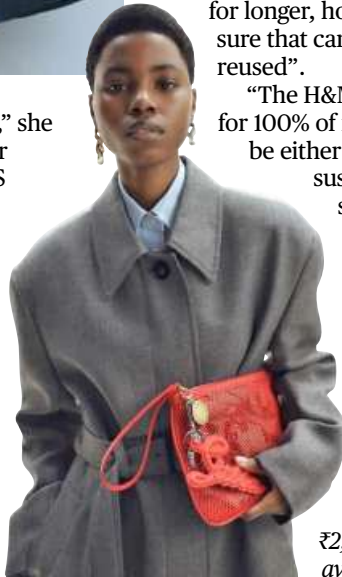
An outfit from the new collection SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



collaboration with Stella is the launch of a brand-new Insights Board, which is uniting different voices and figures from across the fashion industry, to create a space for discussion on issues to do with materials, sustainability and life cycles of clothing," she says, adding that participants include technologist-entrepreneur Kiara Nirghin; model and global brand ambassador Amelia Gray; fashion editor Susie Lau; and model-actor Adwoa Aboah, to name a few.

Going forward, Ann-Sofie says the brand is looking into how "people can enjoy their pieces for longer, how we can make sure that can be recycled or reused".

"The H&M Group aims for 100% of its materials to be either recycled or sustainably sourced by 2030 and net-zero emissions by 2040," she concludes.



Apparel and accessories are priced upwards of ₹2,229 and are available online.

recycled vegetable oil," she says, adding that other materials include RWS (Responsible Wool Standard) certified wool, and ROC certified cotton.

Addressing how this collaboration is different from earlier ones at the brand, Ann-Sofie says it is "about much more than just a collection". "One very important aspect of this new

Art in overflow

As Sarala's Art Centre turns 60, the gallery is putting up an unusual sale

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How is art valued? Through its cultural significance, real-time demand, rarity or the condition of an artwork? The ambiguity is now unfolding inside Sarala's Art Centre, where decades' worth of paintings, prints and sculptures are finding their way back into public view.

As the gallery marks 60 years, it has opened up its archives, which will be available at accessible rates, for an ongoing sale. Expect artworks by celebrated artists like MF Husain and Paritosh Sen.

The gallery has accumulated an enormous collection of works from older acquisitions to more recent additions, leaving it with little room to breathe. "We also had a lack of space since we have too much stuff from the past and also recent works. So we are trying to make it accessible to people and let them enjoy what we do," says Sarala Banerjee, owner of the gallery.

The scale of the archive is staggering. According to her, the gallery has worked with nearly 400 to 500 artists over the years. The current sale alone features works by more than 100 artists, spanning multiple generations,

mediums and styles. Abstract works sit beside landscapes, ink drawings beside figurative studies, tribal art beside contemporary prints. There are lithographs dating back to the late 1980s, Raja Ravi Varma prints, sculptures, and paintings whose labels have long disappeared with time. "Sometimes we have so much art that it is not even named. That is how old some of these paintings are," she says, walking through the stacks of paintings.

Irrespective of the kind of art one is into, there is something for everyone. Sarala, however, seems less interested in the hierarchy of names than in the act of discovery itself. Asked about the most valuable work in the collection, she points briefly to a signed Husain artwork.

"For me, value is how beautiful the work is and how it speaks to me. Personally, names don't matter," she says.

That philosophy perhaps explains the unusual way the sale has been organised. Visitors are encouraged to sift through stacks, pause at unfamiliar names and stumble onto unexpected finds. "I want people to rummage and feel that curiosity and look through the stacks," she says.

The archival art sale at Sarala's Art Centre, Teynampet, is on till May 20.



Sarala Banerjee, owner of the gallery. SANGITA RAJAN



(Clockwise from left) Pathar Bangla, a lamb stew which brought back Tagore's lost appetite in the final days of his life; a file photo of Rabindranath Tagore from the 1950s; and sorshe mangsho or mutton slathered with mustard. THE HINDU ARCHIVES AND LOST AND RARE RECIPES



The poet's pantry

Chef and food archivist Subhajit Bhattacharyya takes us through Tagore's experimental kitchen

Shreya Banerjee

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Every year, on May 7, the birthday of Nobel Prize-winning poet, playwright, composer and polymath, Rabindranath Tagore, returns to Kolkata in songs, art and poetry.

What returns less visibly is a culinary world that once moved through Jorasanko Thakurbari or Tagore's ancestral home, in North Kolkata. These are not recipes in the strict sense, but ideas dating back to the late 18th and 19th centuries that travelled between kitchens, conversations, and texts, and are now difficult to fully recover. This incompleteness becomes an entry point for Subhajit Bhattacharyya. A former media and event management professional,

he, along with fellow event management professional Amit Ghosh Dastidar, co-founded Lost and Rare Recipes, an online culinary archive across YouTube, Instagram, and Facebook, where he uses storytelling to bring dishes from historical texts and regional traditions back into public memory, often with detailed methods and measurements. These include Thakurbari ranna (cooking from the Tagore household), among others.

In Calcutta, particularly under colonial rule, European ingredients and techniques entered certain kitchens. Dishes evolved across geographies, between Dhaka's nawabi influences and Calcutta's emerging urban palate. Within this landscape, the Tagore household occupied a distinct position.

Tagore himself, he adds, was attentive to what he ate. His meals

moved across registers. He enjoyed traditional Bengali food during the day and European dishes like pies, steaks, pastries and cutlets in the evening. This was made possible by access. In colonial Calcutta, although ingredients such as vinegar and bottled sauces were available in select shops, they were expensive. "In ordinary households, these ingredients were not accessible. But in their family, they were used regularly," he says. References to this appear in texts such as *Thakurbari Ranna* (Recipes from the Tagore Household) by Purnima Thakur and in the writings of Pragya Sundari Devi. Recipes included vinegar fish, and maccher sauce curry or fish in tomato sauce curry.

Much of this experimentation was shaped by Mrinalini Devi, Tagore's wife. One of her creations was elo jhelo mishti (haphazard sweet). Tagore is said to have reacted to the dish's name with mild disdain. He renamed it poribondho. While the word has no meaning, Subhajit believes that perhaps the poet called it so because the sweet resembles a pointed gourd closed or bandha.

Tagore hosted the khamkheyali (whimsical) sabha (gathering), an informal gathering of

contemporaries such as Bengali composer Atul Prasad Sen, poet and playwright Dwijendralal Ray, and polymath Jagadish Chandra Bose amongst several others. These evenings were held in rotation at each other's homes. Each host had to serve an unconventional meal.

From these gatherings came dishes that resist easy classification. Combinations such as mangsher machher curry (meat's fish curry) or machher mangsher curry (fish-in-meat curry).

For Subhajit, recreating such dishes involves working with scattered references. On his platform, he documents recipes like pagalkhana mangsho (mad house mutton) a mutton curry that used to be prepared in the paglagarod or psychiatric rehabilitation homes in Bengal.

Towards the end of his life, when Tagore had lost his appetite, he is believed to have responded to panthar bangla, a dish prepared by artist Pratima Devi. It was a light stew of lamb and potatoes. After eating it, his appetite returned. In his final days, he is said to have eaten it more than once.

Tagore's world of food lives on through incomplete recipes and what survives is not completeness, but continuity.



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I have just snagged a reservation at one of Kolkata's hottest new openings. After weeks of trying, I grab the only slot that is available. On a Thursday, at 6pm I reach my destination. "You have arrived," says Google Maps in its usual lacklustre tone. But, have I?

Yokocho is not a speakeasy. But finding it is an adventure – perfect to whet your appetite before diving headlong into its Asian menu. The bar and barbecue is ensconced within the thriving food hub that is Celica Park. A plush lobby, and a lift ride later, I find myself in a dimly-lit alley with mosaic flooring, shuttered storefronts, and brick walls. And then, I finally stumble upon the door I am looking for.

The setting fits the description. "Yokocho in Japanese means an alleyway that's lined with izakayas and eateries," says Chef Auroni Mookerjee, who recently turned restaurateur with this project, along with Abhimanyu Maheshwari, founder of Zing Restaurants and Conversation Room, and Ramesh Agarwal, of Refinery 091, Roots, Romaania, and Conversation Room.

Yokocho is raw yet trendy. There is a hint of nostalgia in the curved space, with old-fashioned switch boards and tungsten bulbs suspended from the ceiling. The interiors suggest you could be anywhere in the world; but the view outside – a tangle of wires and loud restless traffic – is vintage Kolkata.

We sit at the Gangster booth – a cosy four-seater attached to the bar, with a private bartender. As the drinks start flowing, Auroni opens up about the venture and how the bajaar (local market) is where his ideas come alive.

"From Calcutta to Kyoto, every city has their khau gali culture. That's what we are trying to celebrate here," he says. "But we wanted to create something without the pan Asian tropes of dimsum and baos. For us, it was about creating that energy with charcoal at the heart of the kitchen." It took the team a considerable amount of time to get the fire right. While Auroni wanted the scent of the charcoal grill to echo in the space, he did not want it to overpower the setting.

It works. I am distracted by seductive cubes of juicy pork belly currently being grilled for other guests. The charcoal not only fuels the food but also flavours it, smiles Auroni.

Fortunately, our table is brimming with a selection of small plates and Korean-inspired banchan. "On Park Street you have to serve free chakna," says Auroni, as the waiter sets down small bowls of banchan comprising Korean pickles made with local seasonal produce like sheem (broad beans), begun (eggplant), winter cabbage, dried shrimp.

The chef, who has lived and worked in Mumbai and Gurgaon, says one of the reasons he decided to stay in Kolkata (after his stint with Sienna as its executive chef) is because of the produce – be it fiddleheads, snails or fresh water

Lost in Kolkata's Yokocho

Tucked inside Park Street, Chef Auroni Mookerjee's new spot takes inspiration from Japan and features dishes like salmon crudo, pork belly char siu, and whipped tofu with greens, among others

pond mussels. "Everytime I go, I find something new," Auroni smiles.

The drinks also have locally-sourced ingredients like khejur gur and honey from the Sunderbans. My first cocktail has a rectangular and a spherical ball of ice. Called the Spring Water Highball, it is made with water that has been softened for 48 hours. Once whisky is added to it, the blend is carbonated at a lower pressure than soda. It is interesting how much of science and technique goes into bar programmes these days. My favourite is Old Fashioned, New Leaf which appeals to my sweet tooth: Bourbon, pandan leaves, khejur gur and Angostura bitters rally together to create this refreshing drink that is perfect for a humid summer evening.

I start with the first appetiser –



(Clockwise from left) Pork belly char siu; the curved bar; and Shiozake salmon. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

whipped tofu with greens like pui shaag (Malabar spinach), kolmi shaag (water spinach), borboti (yardlong beans), and dheki shaag (fiddleheads), cooked over a charcoal fire that gives a delightfully smoky taste, then topped with pickle and chilli crunch. A simple dish but with many interesting flavours it feels avant garde. The food, Auroni says, is craft forward and performance forward. Everything is done from scratch. Handmade is very important, he says pointing to the little origami cats on each table that are made by the team everyday.

Next, the salmon crudo, with capers, shallots, sea asparagus and lots of tamari, deserves a standing ovation. A dish that Auroni learnt to make watching Anthony Bourdain, it has been inspired by one of the late chef's favourite seafood restaurants, Swan Oyster Depot 975 in San Francisco.

The chicken dashi soup dumplings brimming with slow-cooked chicken broth is comfort food at its best. It is served with soy ginger scallion broth for added measure. I am not a fan of eggplant, but the BBQ Begun with garlic and gochujang has me hooked with its smoky, sweet and spicy notes. Among my other favourites are the pork belly char siu and the duck hangover rice. "We smoke the pork first like how they do in the Northeast and then we leave it on top of the fire. The char is added before sending it to the table," explains Auroni. Technically a Cantonese dish, it has a Bengali twist with aam aada (mango ginger) and a slightly sweet soy caramel sauce.

Most people choose dessert to end their meal but I am so taken up with the duck hangover rice, I know this is the flavour I want to go home with. Kanakchur rice (a variety from Bengal) is cooked with caramelised onion and in a duck stock with an infusion of Asian aromats. Added along with it are potatoes gently roasted in duck fat and an onsen egg with a custard-like yolk. The Bengali in me is delighted with the aloo situation here. I pair it with my pandan cocktail and single-handedly polish off the hangover rice, much to the chef's joy. After this large meal, I sit by one of the large windows and consider a takeaway parcel of their Vietnamese coffee tiramisu. The mind says no. But the heart and Auroni always say yes.

Meal for two costs ₹3,500 with alcohol. At 24, First Floor, Park Centre, Park Street Area.



(Clockwise from right) Beadwork by the women of the Meghwal community; Gauravi Kumari of the erstwhile royal family of Jaipur, the brand's cultural collaborator; Puja Shah, co-founder of Moi; beadwork artefact by the Meghwal community. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

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Long before Gujarati traders bartered cotton for Venetian glass beads in East Africa, the Indus Valley Civilisation had already established terracotta beadmaking traditions in Kutch and Kathiawar. This is the cultural lineage of the region's pastoral communities that husband-wife duo Puja and Kunal Shah, founders of fine-jewellery brand Moi, encountered two years ago while shaping their brand's first exclusive capsule.

"We were looking to curate a jewellery collection that qualified as rare collectables and was only available offline. Searching for inspiration, we toured Kutch looking for motifs and textiles that came with a solid back story," says Puja, who trained as jewellery designer at The Fashion Institute of Technology in New York and worked briefly at Brooklyn Museum and The Metropolitan Museum of Art.

The duo's expedition birthed Moi's Kutch collection, launched last year, which put the spotlight on jewellery-making traditions of Kutch and Kathiawar. That year, the brand also presented its nine-month research on the subject at the Society of



Like a rolling bead

At Moi's London Crafts Week debut, the jewellery brand will exhibit the beadmaking traditions of India's pastoral communities

Jewellery Historians. "One of the key pieces from the Kutch Collectibles, bird brooches, was picked up by Isha Ambani (daughter of billionaires Mukesh and Nita Ambani) and she wore it at the Met Gala last year," remembers Puja.

Kunal brings back the attention to the pastoral communities: "It was during the 15th to 17th Century that communities like the Rabaris, Sindh Jats and Ahirs started working with Venetian glass beads. A lot of motifs were inspired by the region's traditional textile crafts patola and bandhini, but each

community had its distinct beading techniques and motifs. Most of this beaded jewellery was made by women and was an integral part of the bride's trousseau."

Motivated by an impressive response from the urban elite and the global stage, the duo felt the urge to expand its research to the pastoral communities of western India. That is when they found an ally in Gauravi Kumari of the erstwhile royal family of Jaipur, who became the brand's cultural collaborator and gave them access to the beadwork of the Meghwal

community in Rajasthan.

Moi has now distilled its experiences and knowledge into a new collection Serai, which will be unveiled at London Crafts Week (May 13-16), alongside the exhibition Unbound by Beads: Migration, Memory & Material, in collaboration with the Princess Diya Kumari Foundation (PDKF) Artisan Collective. The collective, founded by Gauravi, is an initiative to empower rural Indian women artisans.

"We were serendipitously acquainted with Gauravi through a common friend and



had it not been for her, it would have been hard to find these pastoral communities of Rajasthan. They stay in small hamlets near Barmer and migrate in search of water and work," informs Kunal. It is this very nature of these tribes that inspired the title of both, the exhibition and the collection. "The word unbound comes from beadwork becoming the artistic expression of women in these communities, while migration refers to their nomadic lifestyle. We refer to memory because beadwork techniques are passed down

from a mother to her daughter and the material too differs from one community to another. The Rabaris, for instance, use many different shapes of beads," says Puja.

The exhibition will showcase a total of 35 beaded objects, including 12 jewellery pieces from Serai. "Serai, by the way, means a resting place for the caravan of nomads/tribes," adds Puja. She explains that the artefacts have been categorised in three different sections: Self-Consumption, Ceremonial and Self-Expression. "The people of these communities make these objects for themselves," she shares.

The first section comprises beaded neckpieces, bangles, bhajubands (armlet) and ear accessories, while the second includes beadwork tied to marriage customs, trousseau and public celebration. "Ceremonial artefacts at the exhibit include a pair of beaded anklets, bhajuband, waistchain, sehra (60-65 years old traditional headdress worn by grooms) and a covering for the sword – all of which are a part of the groom's wedding attire," says Puja.

The third segment showcases everyday objects like beaded pankha (fan, 90-95 years old), makhiyaro (90-95 years old decorative ornamentation used for embellishing the cattle), beaded coconuts

(samaiyao) and beaded pots (indhoni; 45 years old), shindga (resembles a horn and is used as a decorative item or a cradle toy and is an icon of good omen). Puja adds, "All the exhibited objects, except the ones from Serai, are the property of Moi. Some were purchased directly from these communities, while others were bought from antique dealers or auction houses."

Speaking of Serai, Puja shares that the collection champions beadwork along with other jewellery making techniques like enamelling and filigree. The limited edition earrings, brooches, and necklaces feature natural gemstones, diamonds, and pearls set in 14 and 18 carat gold. As Serai travels from the salt deserts of Kutch and the migrating settlements of Barmer to the polished galleries of South Kensington, Moi's exhibition ultimately argues that beadwork is not merely ornamentation, but a living archive of movement, memory and survival. Moi's collectible jewellery is therefore documenting a fragile cultural language before it disappears into history.

Moi's Serai collection and exhibition Unbound by Beads: Migration, Memory & Material will be on view at The Lavery in South Kensington, London, from May 13 to 16 (10am-7pm); Serai's limited edit starts at \$10,000.





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Saudi freediver Salma Shaker poses with the flag of her country; the freediver in action. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT



Women are being empowered to excel in sports. It's amazing to see this change, especially when you are a part of it," she says.

Deeper meaning
Freediving is a sport of brutal physiological demands. At 70 metres into the ocean, the lungs are compressed to a fraction of their size, and the heart rate slows to a crawl. In that state freedivers must battle their body's urge to breathe. But Salma rejects this

theory. "You can't fight the body; you have to listen to it and train alongside it," she explains. "I've learned that panic comes from resisting sensations. When you accept them, they soften."

While Salma speaks of the ocean with a sense of wonder, she is under no illusion about the dangers it could pose. "Freediving is an extreme sport, and while you can get injured doing anything incorrectly, the stakes here are higher because we are in an environment we don't fully control. The first rule is to stay humble; you can never be arrogant with the ocean. If there is even a 1% risk, you don't do it. I always tell myself: there will always be another dive, another time."

Last year, Salma competed at Vertical Blue in the Bahamas, often referred to as the Wimbledon of freediving. But for now, she is looking for a different kind of depth. "It's not only about metres anymore. I want to be a mentor for young talent and build a sustainable freediving culture in the region. Maybe even start holding competitions here for free divers from across the world."

For Salma, the goal has shifted from personal records to a broader legacy. She is now making space for others to follow her into the blue.

Making waves, one dive at a time

Saudi freediver Salma Shaker is redefining depth – both, in the ocean and in public perception – as she breaks records and challenges stereotypes

Nivedita Jayaram Pawar

Growing up in the coastal city of Jeddah, Salma Shaker developed an early and enduring connection with the ocean. "I grew up in a family of ocean lovers and divers. I must have been a month or two when my parents introduced me to the Red Sea," she says. What started as a hobby and some relaxing time with the fish soon blossomed into a passionate affair with freediving. "When I found freediving, everything changed. I had never known passion. But when I dived for the first time, I felt something and realised 'is that what people feel when they say they are passionate?' It was a really nice feeling."

In 2019 Salma broke Nada

Alrasheed's record to become the deepest Saudi Woman Freediver. During that historic moment, she spent two minutes and 20 seconds 70 metres under the Red Sea on a single breath. So, how does it feel to be that deep in the ocean? "At that depth, the world becomes very quiet. Sound fades, movement slows and everything feels intimate and internal. There's pressure, of course, but it's the good kind of pressure. It's as if the ocean is giving you a big hug. It reminds you how small you are and genuinely humbles you," she replies.

Breaking stereotypes
Salma's presence on the world stage adds more than just metres to a scoreboard; it dismantles the stereotypes about the participation of women from the Middle East in high-stakes sport. But Salma belongs to a new generation of athletes who are rewriting history with sheer grit. She has become a living example of how the cultural landscape in her country is opening up.

"So much has changed in Saudi in the last five-seven years. I wish people understood that Saudi Arabia is full of layered, curious, driven people who are deeply connected to Nature and sport.

In 2019 Salma broke Nada Alrasheed's record to become the deepest Saudi Woman Freediver. She spent two minutes and 20 seconds 70 metres under the Red Sea on a single breath



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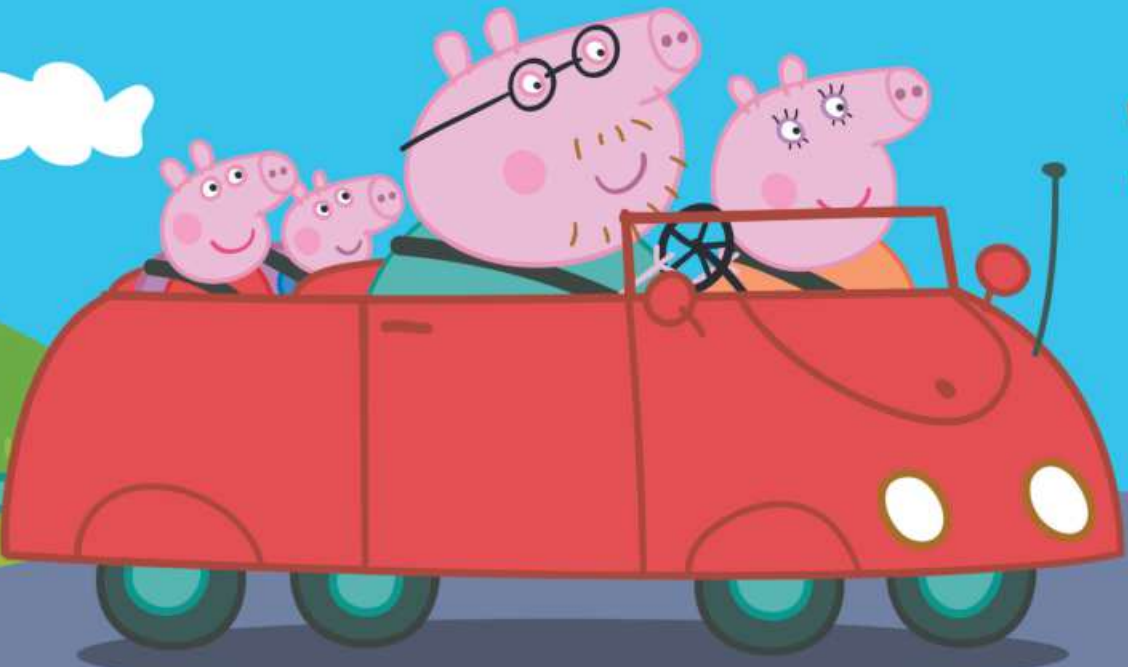
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Malayalam

Engaging and brave despite its predictability

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An almost archaic communication method takes center stage when the characters played by Mammooty and Mohanlal first make contact in Mahesh Narayanan’s *Patriot*, well into the film’s second half. It would seem apt in a way, hinting at the vintage quality of their association while also fitting well inside the theme of the film on digital mass surveillance.

Now, it seems rather ubiquitous, and Mahesh Narayanan appears fully taken in by the urgency to convey these fears to a larger audience. The two superstars are thus tools for this socio-political endeavour rather than the screenplay being in service of their star aura, as often seen in such star-studded movies.

Daniel James (Mammooty), a top-level employee in a Union government ministry, gets a hint of a nefarious surveillance system involving minister JP Sundaram (Rajiv Menon), and his corporate honcho son Shakthi (Fahadh Faasil). He is forced to go on the run to protect himself and uncover the truth.

As far as the story goes, things are straightforward enough to draw a rough outline from the film’s trailer, yet *Patriot* has enough to keep one engaged for a good part.

Rather than painting the issue of surveillance in broad strokes, the screenplay breaks it down as digestible pieces peppered all over the narrative, from a mock phone review in Daniel’s vlog to characters on the run avoiding highway toll gates to avoid being tracked, and a depiction of the way in which a universal identity card can turn into a civilian surveillance tool.

Some of it might seem basic for a tech-savvy audience, but for the film’s reach, this treatment was quite apt. In the middle of it all, *Patriot* also questions those who proudly say they have nothing to hide, while slyly supporting government surveillance.

The current context and the neat stepping away from these issues in most film industries make this a brave film, although the narrative has a predictable air about it..

With the film mostly staying true to its theme, diehard fans looking for high moments might leave the theatre without their expectations from such a rare coming together fully satisfied, except for a car chase scene involving both the stars and an escape sequence. Even the chase sequence ends tamely, leaving one with the feeling that more could have been done with it. There is less scope for banter between the two thanks to the serious episodes.

The minimal screen time for actors like Revathi and Nayanthara comes across as a major disappointment, while Zarin Shihab and Darshana Rajendran get a better deal. Even Mohanlal plays an extended cameo with an abrupt end. Kunchacko Boban and Fahadh Faasil have solid roles. Mammooty gets a character that literally carries the film. Rajiv Menon’s presence is not just a call back to ‘Harikrishnans’. He embodies the inherent evilness of that character.

The last act seemed a bit rushed and followed familiar templates, unlike the nuanced takes in the earlier part of the film. It does not spring any major surprises, except for a bit of history involving the antagonist and his politician father. High production values have been the trademark of Mahesh Narayanan’s films, and in *Patriot*, he ups his as well as Malayalam cinema’s game. Sushin Syam’s understated score fits well with the film’s theme.

Despite its predictable narrative, *Patriot* is an engaging and even brave film on a pertinent issue. It is not often that a questioning “dissident” gets the central role in an Indian film these days.

Patriot is currently running in theatres

Quite a day to remember

Hindi

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At a time when the box office menu is brimming with masala entertainers, *Ek Din* tastes like a palate cleanser. A gentle, heart-tugging alternative to spectacles and morally twisted love stories, the film leans into a quiet, introspective, and emotionally tender atmosphere. Set amidst the corroding corporate culture, where relationships tend to be transactional, it explores how a single shared memory or a single day of connection can feel like an entire relationship. Not a fantasy but a light whimsical sprinkle that makes the impossible feel real, raising questions about identity, fate, truth, and what lingers when everything else fades.

A faithful remake of the Thai film, *One Day, Ek Din*, reminds one of *Saiyaara*. It turns out to be a gentle teacher that gives the romance its



melancholic edge, love its impermanence. And like the young leads of the Mohit Suri film, it hinges heavily on Junaid Khan and Sai Pallavi to make the longing, the magical one day, and the bittersweet aftermath feel transparent and believable.

The plot is simple. Dinesh or Dino (Junaid), a shy, introverted office colleague, silently pines for the vibrant Meera (Sai in her Hindi debut) but lacks the courage to confess, until a company trip to

Japan brings them under a mystical fortune bell. He impulsively wishes for just one day with her as his own – and the wish manifests through a twist of memory, granting him 24 hours of intimacy, shared wonder in scenic Japan, laughter, and deepening connection.

Much like Sai’s presence, the Japanese setting serves as both a novelty and a tonal anchor. The setting’s pristine white, ordered serenity, and polite distance mirror the fragile, temporary nature of

Dino’s constructed intimacy. Where Sai brings an incandescent spontaneity, Junaid Khan responds with a disciplined stillness, creating a captivating tension. We know where it is kind of headed, but the emotional undulations of the journey keep us invested.

With remakes, the emotional translation is often the make-or-break factor, and director Sunil Pandey handles it quite well. Writers Sneha Desai and Spandan Mishra have adapted the fragility of young love, the ache of impermanence, and gentle payoffs into an Indian cultural and linguistic context without diluting its soul or turning it overly melodramatic. The core ingredients feel intimate and believable. For instance, Meera’s fascination for Japan is rooted in her childhood, and Nakul (Kunal Kapoor) only gives it wings. Dino doesn’t become a stalker – and instead evolves into a character defined by vulnerability and shared consequence. In fact, Dino becomes more of a metaphor for him belonging to a different age.

Junaid is refreshingly honest in reflecting Dino’s ordinariness, and that very honesty becomes the film’s ethical spine. Produced by Junaid’s father, Aamir Khan, one could see

Ek Din

Director: Sunil Pandey

Cast: Sai Pallavi, Junaid Khan, Kunal Kapoor, Kavin Dave

Storyline: A diffident Dino silently pines for his out-of-league colleague Meera but lacks the courage to confess. During their company trip to Japan, he wishes at a fortune bell for just one day with her as his girlfriend.

that the screenplay is structured strategically to conceal or minimise Junaid’s acting limitations. The screenplay casts him as an invisible, stiff office colleague who is intentionally low-energy and socially inept, yet carries a noble soul and a curiosity to understand the world. This trope allows stiffness or limited range to read as character choice rather than a performance flaw.

Sai’s emotionally agile performance as Meera carries most of the film’s warmth, chaos, and heartbreak. She elevates what might have been a clever gimmick into something closer to adult

tenderness. Her natural Tamil-inflected Hindi works beautifully in the service of Meera and strengthens the film’s emotional translation as a remake. She completely belongs to the changing demographic of South Indians working in the Noida-Gurugram IT corridor. More importantly, her luminosity doesn’t erase the moral unease around consent – it makes that unease more poignant. Her eyes are not windows to an unguarded soul – they are precisely calibrated instruments. They speak only as much as the screenplay permits, never more. For eyes tired of watching manufactured dazzle with zero interiority, Sai comes across as a whiff of fresh air.

The story is designed so that her struggle with memory and resulting confusion creates the drama and chemistry. Junaid mostly reacts. The good thing is that the film’s architecture is remarkably intuitive, carving out a space where affection flourishes in its distilled form – unspoken, yet resonant. A little more melody in the symphony would have lent the denouement a harmonic shimmer, but still quite a day.

Ek Din is currently running in theatres



Darkness around the Olympic dream

Glory is a gritty, atmospheric thriller that lets formulaic contraptions and uneven gaze overshadow its deeper thematic ambitions

Hindi

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Glory fits right into that popular OTT template where a murder or whodunit serves as the entry point, but the real focus is peeling back layers of a specific society, its pressures, dysfunctions, and cultural realities.

As *Kohrra* subsides from the mindscape, Karan Anshuman takes us to the neighbouring Haryana and pegs a story on the boxing culture rooted in patriarchy that underlines the prosperous State. Karan, known for exposing cricket’s underbelly in *Inside Edge* and power struggles in *Mirzapur*, blends sports drama and crime thriller in a rustic flavour to tell a compelling tale with uneven outcomes.

The mysterious death of a promising Olympic boxing prospect and a brutal assault on his love interest kick things off in Shaktigarh, a boxing hub in Haryana modelled on Bhiwani, the ‘mini-Cuba’ that pugilists call it.

What follows isn’t just a look into who did it, but an exploration of the brutal ecosystem around boxing. Starting from relentless parental ambition and the weight of expectations on young athletes, the narrative ticks off family fractures, toxic masculinity, and the twisted idea of honour, to map the cost of chasing glory.

The brutal assault on their sister Gudiya (Jannat) forces two estranged brothers, Dev (Divyenndu) and Ravi (Pulkit Samrat), to return home. They confront their rigid, medal-obsessed father Raghubir Singh (Suvinder Vicky), a renowned but domineering boxing coach whose relentless pursuit of Olympic success has long fractured the family.

Raghubir had pinned all his hopes on Nihal, but his murder changes the game and gives his rival club, led by Viju Sangwan (Ashutosh Rana), an opportunity to stake a claim to the Olympic berth. Meanwhile, the investigation reveals the social evils festering beneath caste pride. The

Glory

Director: Karan Anshuman, Karmanya Ahuja

Cast: Suvinder Vicky, Divyenndu, Pulkit Samrat, Kashmira Pardeshi, Yashpal Sharma, Ashutosh Rana, Zakir Hussain, Jannat Zubair

Episodes: 7

Storyline: In the boxing hub of Haryana, two estranged brothers reunite with their formidable coach father after the murder of a promising Olympic hopeful and the brutal assault on their sister, pulling them into a dangerous web.



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inspector-in-charge’s wife (Kashmira Pardeshi) turns out to be a bride bought from Bihar to get over the sex ratio and social humiliation. With her self-worth sold, she holds a grudge. Community leaders justify the practice of honour killings to keep the genetic composition sanitised. There is a khap chief (Yashpal Sharma), a pliant police officer (Zakir Hussain), and a flashy mining mafia (Sikandar Kher) lurking in corners of the central ring, adding to the list of suspects.

Suvinder Vicky and Pulkit Samrat form an interesting pair. While Pulkit tends to be more expressive and crowd-pleasing, Suvinder delivers a more internalised, grounded intensity. Divyenndu, as the older brother who loathes the sport’s aggressive nature, carries a soft core beneath that vengeful, cynical exterior. Munna of *Mirzapur* refuses to let the talented actor go, and despite his best efforts, the shadow of *Mirzapur* follows him to the new front as well. Not a bad thing, but in the presence of an absolute chameleon like Suvinder, both the boys look more performative, almost theatrical when it comes to tackling dad issues. Perhaps Karan wants to create a contrast, but it becomes jarringly obvious as the series progresses.

Though the central revelation is genuinely revelatory, *Glory* ultimately retreats from the subversive risks promised by its opening act. Whether due to self-censorship or a lack of narrative conviction, the series trades its early edge for a safe, generic resolution in which the killer’s motivation is only superficially tethered to the complex social terrain the story attempts to navigate.

The sweat-drenched gyms and sharp jabs and hooks in the rings make the boxing action feel grounded, and John Stewart Eduri’s pulsating background score makes it feel visceral, but the makers then take noticeable creative liberties with the rules and regulations of amateur boxing to serve the drama for cinematic impact.

Amid the raw chaos of punches, revenge, and fractured brotherhood, Kashmira’s quiet stance and direct gaze demand attention, but again Karan goes for overkill and turns her into a look-at-me persona.

It seems the makers are in two minds. They take a deep dive into societal undercurrents, but at the same time want to treat the hinterland noir with the Bollywood-friendly tropes of *behen ka badla, kali pahadi ka villain*, and underground boxing. This marriage between gritty realism and larger-than-life drama often feels uneven or forced. Gore and graphic violence in *desi* environs have become a lazy staple, often functioning less as meaningful narrative punctuation and more like a special effect dangled for shock value and binge retention.

This relentless urge to create a spectacle out of the specks of dust comes at the expense of seamless integration, resulting in a series with strong individual parts that doesn’t fully land as a cohesive whole for viewers attuned to logical consistency and tonal balance.

Glory is currently streaming on Netflix.

Unchosen

Creator: Julie Gearey

Cast: Asa Butterfield, Molly Windsor, Fra Fee, Aston McAuley, Alexa Davies, Lucy Black, Olivia Pickering, Siobhan Finneran, Christopher Eccleston

Episodes: 6

Storyline: A stranger strikes a discordant note in a reclusive cult



Streaming

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Stories set in secret cults are always fascinating given the ritual, rules, costumes, charismatic leader, taboos, the frisson of crossing the line between desire and duty, and physical and psychological violence. Amazingly, Julie Gearey has put these elements together to create a show that is as dull as ditchwater. Inspired by a chance meeting Gearey had with a woman belonging to a cult at a grocery store and real-life conservative religious groups including the Plymouth Brethren, *Unchosen* starts off half-way promising but soon devolves into earnest silliness.

Rosie (Molly Windsor)

lives with her husband, Adam (Asa Butterfield), who is a rising star in their religious order, Fellowship of the Divine, and their six-year-old daughter Grace (Olivia Pickering). Rosie's sheltered and restricted life falls apart when Grace, who is hard of hearing, wanders off and falls into a lake. She is rescued by a stranger, Sam (Fra Fee), towards whom Rosie feels gratitude and unease. Though Adam's brother, Isaac (Aston McAuley) uses a cell phone to get Grace to the hospital quickly, it violates the rules in the Fellowship of the Divine and he has to be punished. The leader, Phillips (Christopher Eccleston) wants Adam to prove his loyalty to the fellowship through his treatment of his brother's transgressions. It is not just the phone for Isaac, as he wants to leave his wife Hannah (Alexa Davies) and the cult to be with the woman he

loves. Meanwhile, Sam has ingratiated himself with the fellowship to the extent that no one looks too closely at his history. Every twist and turn can be seen a mile away and if you still do not get it, the subtitles helpfully say "ominous music." It is a shame to see all these wonderfully talented actors defeated by lackadaisical writing. Butterfield, who was engaging as Otis in *Sex Education* is reduced to telegraphing confusion with a mild frown. Where is the heartbreak and ruination as one's beliefs, and all that one holds dear, come crashing down? The same is true of Windsor, who is either running frantically like Tom Cruise or looking tremulous. Fee looks menacing and vulnerable by turns while Eccleston is a textbook repressed elder. Where Jimmy in *28 Years Later: The Bone Temple* is all smiles and tenderness with a chilling side of

psychopathy, Phillips is patriarchy wielded like a sledgehammer. Siobhan Finneran (O'Brien) as Mrs Phillips is even more poorly served. She is the standard-issue moral authority figure, with no interior life whatsoever. Unlike other cult shows, including *Under the Banner of Heaven*, where religion is a lived reality for its characters, *Unchosen* leans towards gestures and music to signal important things are being felt. This is funny for a bit and then just gets tiresome. None of the transgressions feel earned because no time is spent on the effect of a character going against a belief system they have grown up with. While the impossibly hilarious ending signals the possibility of a sequel, one can always hope better sense prevails.

Unchosen is currently streaming on Netflix

Snippets



Ram Charan's movie Peddi to hit theatres on this date

Peddi, starring Ram Charan and directed by Buchi Babu Sana, has wrapped up the filming. Originally shot in Telugu, the pan-Indian film has locked its release date. Backed by producer Venkata Satish Kilaru under Vriddhi Cinemas, and presented by Mythri Movie Makers and Sukumar Writings, *Peddi* has been mounted on a massive scale. Also starring Shivarajkumar and Janhvi Kapoor, the movie will hit the screens on June 04, 2026. The makers of *Peddi* has locked the date after the postponement of *Toxic: A Fairytale for Grown-Ups*. The Yash-starrer, co-produced by KVN Productions, was set to release on June 04, 2026. The makers have postponed the movie saying they "are aligning global distribution."



Sonakshi Sinha and Jyotika's courtroom thriller gets release date

Sonakshi Sinha and Jyotika's upcoming courtroom thriller, *System*, will be released on Prime Video on May 22, the streamer announced. Directed by Ashwini Iyer Tiwari, the film also stars Ashutosh Gowariker, Preeti Agarwal, Adinath Kothare, Aashriya Mishra, Gaurav Pandey, and Sayandeep Gupta in pivotal roles. As per a press release, "The story focuses on a privileged prosecutor who teams up with a humble stenographer to uncover buried injustices, forcing a choice between power and justice." The film has been produced by Pammi Baweja, Harman Baweja, and Smitha Baliga under the banner of Baweja Studios.



Dacoit actor Adivi Sesh to headline two romantic-dramas

Actor Adivi Sesh, who was recently seen in the actioner, *Dacoit*, will be headlining two romantic-dramas next. As per a press release shared by the actor's team, one of the two romantic films will be directed by Sai Marthand, known for the Telugu hit *Little Hearts*. After *Dacoit*, the actor will focus on his action franchise, G2, the sequel to *Goodachari*, after which he will start work on the romantic-dramas. Speaking about it, Adivi said in a statement, "Over the last few years, I've explored intense, high-stakes narratives, and I'm grateful for how strongly they've connected. At the same time, I've been feeling a strong pull towards stories that are more intimate and emotionally driven."



Try to jumpstart am inert sequel

While the fabulous clothes, witty comebacks and warm callbacks are packed in, what this sequel lacks in spades is urgency

English

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There is one pun, "Miranda Beastly", one slightly witty quote, "May the bridges I burn light my way", and another vaguely smart one: "You are not a visionary, you are a vendor" in this sequel to 2006's *The Devil Wears Prada*. The latter of the three flatters to deceive because if you are a good vendor, shouldn't you be able to sell your vision? That, however, is not the real problem with *The Devil Wears Prada 2*. While it is good to hang with the imperious editor of the fashion magazine, *Runway*, Miranda Priestly (Meryl Streep), earnest Andy (Anne Hathaway), haughty Emily (Emily Blunt) and steadfast Nigel (Stanley Tucci); what is in woeful short supply is hunger. The original, based on Lauren Weisberger's 2003 bestselling novel, a savage critique of the fashion industry, was not afraid to feature grey characters. Everyone was hungry to make it – the models, the clackers, the writers, the designers, the second and third assistants. Andy buys into the Kool-Aid, all the while telling herself and her friends that she just has to survive Miranda for a year to have all journalistic doors open for her. By contrast the sequel (David Frankel returns to direct) has sanded down and sanitised everything and everyone. Miranda is more of an institution than a person. The stakes are never too high – nothing like getting the unpublished *Harry Potter* manuscripts in three hours,

The Devil Wears Prada 2

Director: David Frankel

Cast: Meryl Streep, Anne Hathaway, Emily Blunt, Justin Theroux, Kenneth Branagh, Stanley Tucci

Storyline: Twenty years later, Andy returns to *Runway* to find things different and the same



which had us cheering Andy on even as we shake our heads in horror at Miranda's unreasonable requests. In the sequel, after complaints to HR, Miranda hangs her coats herself and has an assistant, Amari (Simone Ashley), murmuring all the necessary politically correct terms Miranda should use, which in itself is an anomaly, as surely someone as intelligent and clued in as Miranda, who has managed to stay a step ahead in

the most fickle of industries, would not need a road map to navigate the world. Twenty years after her Miranda experience, Andy is a respected journalist but, just before receiving an award for her article at a gala, she and all the reporters are fired (by text). *Runway* and Miranda are in trouble for running a piece on a fashion house that uses sweatshop labour. Andy is brought in for damage control. She finds Miranda out of step, Nigel continuing to be the beacon, Emily having moved into retail, and a fading publishing industry – no one reads the print version of *Runway* anymore, Nigel says solemnly. Milan Fashion Week seems to be the last hurrah, what with Miranda travelling economy (unbelievable) and people being asked to take Uber instead of private cars. The pace is glacial and Miranda from the first movie would not have been thrilled, but here she is quite happy to play nice. Kenneth Branagh is cheerfully charming (no strange accent, alas) as Stuart, Miranda's latest husband, while Lucy Liu plays a Garbo-esque figure who is described as the holy grail of interviews, though Andy manages to get one pretty easily through the dog trainer? Justin Theroux is hilarious as the tech bro who wants to travel to the sun. Andy's new love interest Peter (Patrick Brammall) is also quite vanilla, as are their disagreements. The clothes (Molly Rogers takes over from Patricia Field) are flamboyant and unreal rather than aspirational. There is nothing terribly wrong with this hysterically safe movie, but neither is there anything to love passionately. That's all.

The Devil Wears Prada 2 is currently running in theatres